Aisling centre

Hope Healing Growth

Annual Report

2019 – 2020



Celebrating 30 years of Service in the local community

www.theaislingcentre.com

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Aisling centre
Hope Healing Growth

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Beyond my Wildest Imagingings

30 Years of Aisling Centre

Celebrating the 30th anniversary of the beginnings of the Aisling Centre feels like a very fitting way to enter this new decade.

The word Aisling means dream. The Centre was the dream of one woman, Mary Daly. From her work in the wider Enniskillen community, she became aware of people's need for a listening ear. She also saw the need for a neutral space, a safe place, where people would be free to talk. It was she who walked the streets looking for a suitable place to buy before settling on 37 Darling Street which was then a regular three-storey dwelling house. Minimal renovations were carried out.

Helena Hunt and I came on board when all the heavy lifting was done. We moved in as a group of three in September 1990, and began to live, as it were, above the shop. Just to give a picture of the physical layout of the building. Our three bedrooms were on the third floor. The second floor was kitchen, sitting room, office and counselling room. On ground floor was reception room, counselling room, a much smaller coffee shop which was supplied from the kitchen we used ourselves upstairs. At the back of coffee shop was a group room with a hatch linking both rooms so it was really an extension of the coffee shop. This was a very popular room, people spent hours in there chatting, supporting one another and because it was before the smoking ban, all done through a haze of smoke.

We had a wonderfully warm welcome extended to us by all our neighbours on Darling Street. They called in, wished us well, and many gave donations towards the work that was about to begin. This was a great act of faith on their part because we were vague enough ourselves about what exactly that work would be. There was no strategic plan, no financial plan, just a strong desire to help whatever the need that walked in the door.

We had a few core beliefs. We wanted the Centre to be a welcoming place for everyone, no matter what tradition or background. The decor was warm, the atmosphere homely, not clinical. Counselling was a relatively new concept in Fermanagh in 1990, mental health was a difficult subject and carried a lot of stigma.

When I joined the Aisling Centre, I had just returned from two years study in California. At that time in California, you would not be talking to anyone in general conversation for five minutes before they would say: *"when I was talking to my therapist yesterday I said..... he said"* and the whole story would pour out. We were a long way from that type of conversation in Boho, Enniskillen or anywhere in Fermanagh at that time.

So we were living there, the decor was finished, still we were reluctant to take the next step: to open the doors. A business woman who had helped us buy equipment for the coffee shop gave this advice which I have never forgotten, *"You will never be completely ready, there will always be something else to be done, so just pick a date and open."* So with great trepidation we opened the doors on November 11th 1990 and waited to see would anyone come.

They came. Trade was brisk in the coffee shop that first day. I think the takings were £68. Gradually over the coming weeks the trickle of people for counselling began and they have been coming ever since. Need walked in the door and also people who were able to answer that need. We worked with colleagues in the then Sperrin Lakeland Trust mental health and addiction teams, Nexus, Relate and others, all rowed in. The person's need was the most important thing and they were signposted to the most appropriate agency in the building, a model of working which still exists to this day.

Another very key factor in the early development of Aisling Centre was the establishment of a management committee. These men and women drawn from across the community and with a variety of skill sets were vital in giving strong leadership to the Centre in those early precarious days.

So you can appreciate the great joy I feel 30 years later. The Aisling Door remains open. The physical layout of the building has changed beyond recognition. But the ethos of the Centre remains the same, a warm welcoming atmosphere; an open door for those who need a listening ear and professional support. The management committee continue to provide vision, oversight and wisdom. The present brilliant manager and team continue to give a professional service second to none and provide essential services for hundreds who visit the Centre every year.

All of this would have been beyond my wildest imaginings in 1990.

Sr. Edel



Chairperson's Foreword



This is my last report as Chairperson, after six years I am finally stepping down, and will be ably replaced by our Vice-Chair, Alison Annan. My good wishes to her for the next three years and many thanks for her support and advice during my time as Chairperson.

As I reflect on the past six years, what stands out most for me is the exponential growth in Aisling during that period. While it may not look very different from six years ago, the serene face of Aisling hides an enormous increase in activity, generated from the year on year increase in need.

In 2015/16 we were receiving an average of 37 referrals per month, with 369 clients attending for counselling that in itself being a significant increase from the previous years; today that number has more than doubled. We receive an average of 80 referrals a month and this year, 801 people (adults and children) attended counselling at the Centre. We now offer in excess of 100 sessions of counselling weekly and our steadily growing therapy team has increased from 10 to 16, with plans in place for further recruitment in the coming year!

One of the highlights of my term in office was the 25th Anniversary year, a busy year of celebration and fundraising, culminating in the grand Gala Ball in October 2015. But throughout this, and all the other significant milestones, Aisling Centre never once lost sight of the ever increasing need and remains on course delivering hope and healing to the people of our community.

2019/20 has been another busy year for Aisling Centre. Alongside the body of work detailed in this report we also reviewed and set our strategic plan for the next three years.

As always community support for Aisling Centre has been amazing. This year we were the nominated charity for Enniskillen Rotary Club and the Serverfield Cycle as well as receiving countless donations from the wider community. All much appreciated, enabling us to grow the service.

In September 2019 we learnt that Aisling Centre had been nominated for the Queen's Award for Voluntary Service. This was undoubtedly the highlight of my six year tenure. The assessment meeting in November with Deputy Lieutenants John Graham, Melanie Little and Joanna McVey who acted as scribe, was actually a fun occasion and a chance for us to reflect on the wonderful work undertaken by Aisling Centre volunteers. We were so excited when we heard that we had been short-listed! That alone was a great achievement.

We were told the awards would be announced June 20 and while, technically that falls into another financial year, at the time of writing this report, the news is out. Aisling Centre has been granted the Queen's Award for Voluntary Service, we were over the moon. By the time June had arrived we were living in a very different world, and we had to take to social media to share the good news with the community.

Congratulations to all our loyal volunteers who often work behind the scenes, but are invaluable in their help and commitment, this is a fitting recognition of all their hard work. We will definitely mark the occasion later in the year, but that is for Alison and next year's report!

2020 is another milestone year for Aisling Centre as we celebrate our 30th birthday. Celebrations began in January at the first event of the year, the increasingly popular, Hope Healing and Growth Well-Being Event. As always it was a wonderful day and it raised over £6,000.00 for Aisling Centre. My thanks to fellow Director, Aideen McGinley and her team of volunteers for all their hard work in organising and making the HHG event such a success.

However, all our eagerly anticipated plans for 2020 and our 30th anniversary year came to an abrupt halt with the arrival on our shores of COVID-19 and the ensuing lockdown in March. Regardless, we were determined that we would not be halting our counselling service. Demand if anything was rising with the stress and enforced isolation. I would like to pay tribute to the whole team (counsellors and admin) who worked so hard as we made the switch to telephone/e-counselling. This is by no means an easy option, it was a steep learning curve by all concerned and hats off to them for rising to the occasion!

I would like to thank and acknowledge the sterling work done by Bridie Sweeney, centre co-ordinator and John Bennett, clinical co-ordinator who worked in isolation from the premises and did what was necessary to keep the show on the road in difficult and unprecedented conditions. I don't believe we could have maintained services without their organisational skills and dedication.

So as we enter the final quarter of 2019/2020, I can only say that we are in a very different world to where we were this time last year, but thanks to everyone associated with Aisling Centre we continue to forge ahead, healing and giving hope to our community. As always I wish to thank everyone on the team from the essential workers like the cleaners (even more vital in today's world of COVID-19), right up through the ranks, many unseen but all a vital cog in the running of Aisling Centre. Thank you one and all.

One of my final duties as Chairperson was to initiate a review of the Board and the development of a succession planning process. It is always important to take stock and engage in regular review. It has helped ensure that Aisling Centre maintained its clear focus and ethos over the past 30 years. This work will be progressed in the months and years ahead.

Three long-standing members of the Board of Directors will be standing down at our AGM – Sr Edel Bannon, Sr Mary deLacy and Pat Cassidy. These stalwarts have given many, many years to Aisling Centre and will be greatly missed by all of us on the Board. I want to thank them and indeed all the Directors for their hard work and commitment to Aisling Centre and for the great support they have given me during my time as Chairperson.

It has been a great honour to serve as Chairperson of this wonderful organisation and I look forward to continuing to serve as a member of the Board of Directors.

Ann

Reports

Centre Co-ordinator



As always the annual report creates a space to look back on the year and acknowledge the work that has been done. 2019/20 has certainly been a busy year for Aisling Centre as we continue to see growing demand for services.

This report attempts to document and give a flavour of some of the work undertaken at Aisling Centre by our dedicated team of volunteers and paid workers; all of whom are committed to the ethos of welcome, caring and hope that is Aisling Centre. Sincere thanks to each and every one of you.

We do this work with the support of the local community and I would like to say a great big thank you to the many individuals and organisations who continue to support our work. Also to the excellent GP Practices, Schools and Community Groups who facilitate our outreach work. A special word to the many groups who work in Aisling Centre, you are very important to us and play an important role in making Aisling Centre a place of hope, healing and growth. I would also like to pay tribute to our funders for their unwavering belief in and, support of our work. It is thanks to them that we were able to continue counselling as we moved into lockdown.

2019/20 has also been a special year as January marked the beginning of Aisling Centre's 30th anniversary year. We owe our founding members Sr Mary Daly, Sr Helena Hunt (deceased) and Sr Edel Bannon a debt of gratitude. I have no doubt that they will find great joy in knowing that their dream (grounded in hard work and reality) continues to thrive and provide essential support for the local community.

As the year draws to a close we see some changes in our Board of Directors as long-serving Directors Sr Edel Bannon, Sr Mary deLacy and Pat Cassidy step down from the Board. And while change is healthy and indeed necessary to maintain a strong organisation, their commitment and valuable contribution will be much missed. Their long association with Aisling Centre has helped lay the foundation for a wonderful organisation that I and my colleagues feel privileged to work in. We also look forward to welcoming and working with newly appointed chairperson Alison Annan as Ann McDermott steps down, having completed her term of office.

Ann has been a steady hand as she steered Aisling Centre through a time of change and significant growth. She has also been a wonderful mentor and I thank her for her encouragement and guidance. Her commitment and concern for the welfare of both Aisling Centre team and clients has always underpinned her work. I know the whole team will join with me in thanking her for all her support over the last six years. Indeed thanks to all of the Directors for their on-going sterling work and commitment to Aisling Centre. It is a pleasure to work with you.

The year ended in March 2020 with COVID-19 and lockdown. It has brought with it a time of change and uncertainty. But, it will pass and in the meantime Aisling Centre remains steadfast in its commitment to continuing to provide services to the local community.

Bridie

Clinical Co-ordinator



Photographs taken in the Aisling Centre spanning its 30 years of existence, chart a history of development, growth and change. People remark on how the building has transformed, extended and modernised; they smile while looking at the faces of friends and colleagues who are many years younger in the photos. They recall the seed of an idea rooted in a desire to improve the quality of life for people who for whatever reason experienced discomfort and distress within themselves and their lives, and they remember the vision that brought the Aisling Centre into being, giving them local access to professional counsellors, psychotherapists and play therapists.

30 years have witnessed great change outside of the building too. When the Aisling Centre opened, mental health and wellbeing was very much the poor relation in health care and service provision, and while there have been great strides made, there is still some way to go before we can honestly say that mental and physical health are valued equally. At the same time, the old photographs remind us that the Aisling Centre has played its part in narrowing the gap, helping to change people's attitudes and lessening the stigma that was there.

Volunteers and staff and, clients whose lives have been changed because of coming to Aisling have ensured that the service has remained open so that Fermanagh continues to have this safe and welcoming space where those who need to, can talk and explore the suffering they live with, without fear of judgement but in an environment of respect and acceptance of them as they are. For people who come here either because they have found the courage to seek help or as is sometimes the case, out of desperation for help, it has often been described as a journey that is both difficult and rewarding. It is difficult because we don't avoid the pain or wish it away but in the safety of a therapeutic relationship, we accept it and work to understand it. It is rewarding because when done in the right environment healing and change become possible.

This year it is fitting that on behalf of our clients we thank all the volunteers for their part in helping to change lives for the better over the 30 years.

John

Services

"Thank you to both my counsellor and the Aisling Centre for the much needed support"

Demand for counselling continues to be high. A total of 956 requests for counselling was received, an average of 80 per month.

754 Adults and 47 Children received counselling.

The nature of the work means that waiting lists and times for counselling will fluctuate depending on demand. This year, despite dealing with the largest number of referrals since the Centre opened, waiting times have consistently been at their shortest in recent years.

Adults Counselling Service

67% female, 32% male, 1% transgender

SOURCE OF REFERRAL	
Self	30%
GPs	50%
CMHT & Other Health Professionals	11%
C&V and Private sectors	9%

CORE Evaluation
78% clinical impact
22%

Overall experience of the centre			
Excellent 86%	Good 13%	Fair 0%	No Ans 1%

Level of support received			
Excellent 89%	Good 11%	Fair 0%	No Ans 0%

Reported levels of Distress/Upset before and after therapy			
	Before		**After**
High	76%	High	2%
Moderate	19%	Moderate	21%
Mild	4%	Mild	57%
None	0%	None	19%
No answer	1%	No answer	1%

95% reported feeling more positive about the future after therapy.

"Thank you, it has really helped me through a difficult time when I didn't know what to do or where to turn"

Stacey

Stacey was a working mum with two pre-school children At her initial assessment Stacey said that she had always been a bit shy and a worrier, however since having her own children that had developed into anxiety and low self-esteem.

Stacey described her various experiences of anxiety ranging from panic like symptoms, intrusive thoughts, a very critical self-narrative all of which robbed her of an ability to be present and enjoy the positive aspects of her life. A huge part of Stacey's anxiety was always fearing the worst would happen and the consequences that would have for her children. Her over-exposure to global news issues and her over-use of internet searches fuelled Stacey's anxiety. Stacey's self-worth was diminished more by her use of social media and comparing herself to what she saw there.

Stacey hoped that counselling would help her cope with her anxiety and feel more content in herself. Stacey wanted to be a good mum. She described her own childhood as happy and she wanted to be a good mum for her children. Social media, made her feel 'not good enough'.

In the first session Stacey was encouraged to 'name' her anxiety, identifying it for what it was, enabling her to discuss it in a more unemotional and self-compassionate way. Then looking at the nature of her anxious thoughts the counsellor discussed with Stacey common trends of distorted thinking patterns, such as expecting the worst case scenario, seeing things in black and white, magnifying certain 'problems' and minimising other strengths. This process allowed Stacey to somewhat normalise her experience of anxiety.

Over time Stacey said she was able to identify her 'wonky' thoughts and challenge them more easily enabling her to 'ground' herself more in the here and now and put coping strategies in place should worst case scenario happen. She was able to do this without experiencing the panic-like symptoms she had in earlier sessions.

Stacey also began to see that anxiety to a certain extent in life is inevitable and the realistic option was to learn to manage it. A huge part of this was for Stacey to 'lower the bar' of expectation she puts on herself to be good enough.

Evidence testing and reality basing techniques were used to illustrate exceptions to her negative core belief and highlight where she was succeeding - her children were happy, she had achieved everything she aimed for in life. Stacey recognised that it was unrealistic for her to expect to mother her children in this modern globalised world the way she was raised by her mother. Also Stacey's reference point for being 'good enough' was often based on what she saw online and on social media. She realised over time that this basis for comparison was a misrepresentation of people's day to day experience.

By the end of therapy Stacey was back involved with her mother/toddler group and felt the benefit from the shared, real lived experience from others in similar situation to herself. Stacey's more self-compassionate stance allowed her to try medication also which she had been taking for a month.

Stacey said at the end of counselling she had gained insight into how she thought about and processed anxiety. She recognised the patterns her thinking took and allowed herself to go through that process, knowing where she could intervene and what her options were. Stacy attended for 12 sessions.

What worked well?

"Comfort of rooms and atmosphere."

"Warm, calm environment; relaxing music, friendly reception."

"It was scary at first for me to come but when I did it has been fantastic"

"Flexibility of appointments, friendly staff and the professionalism of the staff while still feeling welcome."

"My counsellor was hugely helpful whilst being empathetic and understanding. She helped me bring a practicality and logic to my thinking which impacted on my perception of anxiety and stressful situations.

[The therapist] was extremely insightful and I felt that her input was very useful. She didn't just sit and nod."

"How friendly people were and I felt they really wanted to listen to me when others didn't."

"I felt very comfortable attending the service. Lovely, calm relaxed atmosphere, felt very confidential."

"Talking about my past and being given tools to deal with my emotions and feelings."

"A hugely belated thank you for helping me make sense and find peace with so much. I have felt lighter and more free than ever before. I so appreciate everything you did and said and the 'space held' for me. It has made and will continue to make a huge difference to my life. Thank you again."

"Very private and very good. Receptionist lovely, welcoming first approach. Person making initial phone call made me feel very relaxed."

"I so needed to be able to talk to someone who didn't criticise me and think I was mad."

Areas for improvement?

Overall feedback was positive, although a small number of clients mentioned poor signage in the Centre particularly around the Head Street entrance; this has been addressed.

There were also some comments on the amount of paperwork required by some funders which needed to be completed in the first session.

General Feedback

"Thank you for helping me. Thank you for giving me permission to experience my pain and confusion that goes back several years. Thank you for helping me accept my less than perfect self and move forward with same."

"Although I don't believe now was the right time for me to have counselling, I am still taking a lot away from it to help me make positive changes in my life. Thank you for an amazing service"

"I cannot thank [my therapist] enough for his help. I did not for one second feel judged or rushed. It is an excellent service."

"It has been a great experience and has opened my eyes to a lot of things about myself. I shall always be very grateful for this opportunity that has been given to me"

"Counselling was so supportive for my stress and anxiety. Would recommend it to my family and friends. I found a new lease of life in a short time. Thanks again to the team"

"Very thankful and grateful for the therapy I received. It should be more available! If it were more available many lives would be saved".

"I was an anxious wreck before using this service and after every session, I've come away feeling a bit more positive and hopeful"

John

John is a middle aged married man with adult children. He is a retired army officer dealing with a number of health issues comprising of asthma, hearing loss, sleep disorder and muscular pain. John has a very good relationship with his wife and they have a very close bond. They have built a good life together and live *"comfortably"* he would say. John is a lifelong teetotaller and has a strong faith attending his local church weekly.

At the first meeting John completes some of the assessment tools which help identify some of the main issues impacting on his life at this time. John cores in the moderate to high range.

John is quite nervous at this first meeting and asks if he can sit facing the door. He is a chatty man and is very curious about the counselling process having never experienced it before. He is somewhat sceptical as to how it will help him. I explain in detail the process of therapy and he agrees to meet initially for 6 sessions and then review.

Over the coming weeks John religiously attends his counselling sessions. He discusses his health issues and speaks about the constant pain and tiredness he experiences due to all the various health concerns he now has to live with. He speaks of his anger and frustration at not been able to do normal day to day manual jobs that he once was able to perform.

As therapy progresses John begins to open up gradually about the constant flashbacks he has at night when he is trying to go to sleep, this is the norm for him and he feels it will always be this way.

However, as the weeks pass John slowly begins to trust the therapy process and the therapist, he becomes more at ease and is able to talk about the experiences he had during his time in the army. John spoke of the many friends and comrades he lost during the height of the troubles and is quite emotional and upset as he remembers these traumatic times in his life. He spoke of how he has been *"targeted to be shot"* on numerous occasions over the years. He discussed the guilt and worry he had over leaving his wife and family to work long hours. He spoke of the anger and frustration at how he and his comrades were treated by the government and feels 'left behind and forgotten'.

Over the months John continued with therapy and learned a lot about himself. This helped him develop a more balanced and kinder way of thinking about his life. He found his sleep pattern improved and the flashbacks were not as frequent. His mood improved and some of his ailments and illnesses abated somewhat.

John was grateful that he had the opportunity to attend therapy and found it very helpful. It has also given him skills and tools to use as he continues to move forward with his life.

"Fantastic service and we are lucky to have it in Enniskillen"

Play Therapy Service

47 children and young people availed of counselling/ play therapy 24 girls and 23 boys.

Source of referral	
Parent	38%
Others (with parental permission)	
School	34%
GP or other Health professional	28%

Main Presentations	
Bereavement	45%
Family Separation	40%
Multiple Loss	11%
Loss due to illness	4%

11% of children also presented dealing with transgenerational trauma.

Child Feedback

"Coming here helped me to feel less sad and that's because I was able to talk about her and my feelings about missing her and being sad, so it helped me a lot. I also liked the fact the we had fun, we were both very funny, even though we talked about some sad things."

"My family feels sad and I don't talk about my brother cause it would make daddy sad."

"Cause it kinda makes me feel a bit better to know he isn't a bad person, to know that he has a mental health thing and I now know that it's not my fault."

"Cause mostly things are not good things are crazy unlike when we were in our old house and that makes me feel angry."

Parental Feedback

"My daughter is not afraid to talk to me anymore about her feelings. She will tell me how she feels and will cry in front of me now rather than hiding it and letting it build up inside her which used to turn to anger".

"Therapist has been amazing and has given my daughter a huge tool box of skills to help deal with her emotions and work through her day to day anxieties. Her general well-being and approach to life is much more positive".

Barry

Eight year old Barry lives with his mother and siblings and is the middle child. His parents are separated which resulted in Barry moving home and school. Both of his parents have new partners. Barry and his siblings have regular contact and visits with their father.

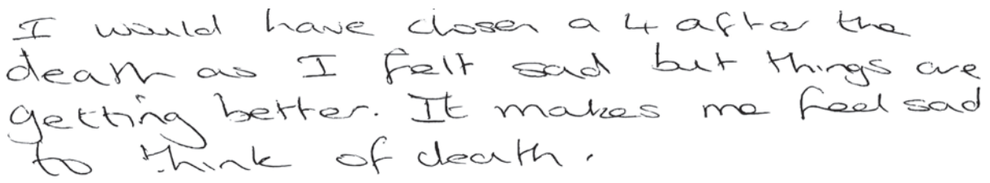
At the initial session with Barry and his mother, they talked about the changes that have taken place in Barry's life and the impact of this for Barry. They both talked about angry behaviours displayed by Barry and his mum stated that she felt this was having an effect on all the family. Barry agreed with this and talked a little about his anger. They both spoke about him coming to therapy so that he could have a private space where he could express these feelings with a trusted adult and ultimately find more appropriate ways for him to express them at home.

As the sessions progressed and Barry talked about his anger and reasons for it, it became evident that he was struggling with the changes in his family. He spoke of challenges he was experiencing within his family relationships that often led to angry outbursts. It was becoming a repeated pattern, leading to evident feelings of low self-esteem and shame, which frequently added to his behaviours.

During reviews with Barry, his parents and step-parent, Barry was able to voice these difficulties in a safe space provided, for all the adults to hear his experiences and feelings. It also allowed a space for his parents and step-parent to discuss possible ways for them to help Barry in finding more appropriate ways to express himself. They were also able to explore solutions to overcoming the challenges.

As the therapy reached its final stages, Barry began to talk about positive changes, especially in regard to some of his relationships. Both Barry and his mum reported that, although there were still some angry displays of behaviours, they had greatly reduced. His mum noted that, as a result of Barry attending therapy, she had come to realise that Barry's behaviours were as a result of him trying to express what he was experiencing, as opposed to him being a 'bold' child. This awareness has resulted in better communication between them.

Barry attended for 12 sessions. During that time there were still many changes taking place in Barry's life. Both Barry and his mum noted this and were aware that Barry will need to be further supported by his family, in order to adjust and manage these changes. Both felt more up to the task as they were equipped with the tools and coping strategies developed during therapy.



Well-Being & Life Learning Services

"I feel like I can handle my emotions a lot better now and feel comfortable that this Centre has offered me a safety net."

Complementary Therapy

70 people availed of CT
77% were victims/survivors of the troubles
9% were clients dealing with the aftermath of suicide
14% presented with general stress/anxiety
86% of clients attended a full programme of treatment

MyMop Impact Scores

Reported Improvements 91%

Client Feedback

"My treatments were amazing. I lead a very lonely life and find it then hard to cope with my health conditions. These were like a tonic and break for myself. They really helped my mood and helped me stay positive."

"The programme was excellent. I had never had reflexology before and was very sceptical of it, but really found it helped me every way, both mentally and physically. I have a busy routine and am more balanced and calm. My sleep pattern has really improved."

"The treatments made me so relaxed and soothed my ongoing pains. They gave my mood a lift as well."

Mindfulness Meditation

Mindfulness Programme Feedback

Unfortunately our 8-week MBSR programme was cut short due to COVID-19 and we were unable to do a full evaluation of the programme.

"Just to say, I really enjoyed the course and Siobhan facilitated it with a calm empathetic and encouraging voice. I am using my meditation at this very difficult time we are going through. Thank you so much."

FODC

Peace
Northern Ireland - Ireland
European Regional Development Fund

Phase 2 - Programme

Nutrition & Health
Nuala Lilley (Nature's Choice)

As a society we are becoming increasingly aware of the links between diet and well being. However there is so much information 'out there', some of it conflicting, it can seem almost impossible to make good choices about food.

Well-known locally for her clear and informed nutritional guidance Nuala's *"Steps to Health"* presentation was informative and practical. *"Improving your diet doesn't have to be difficult"* she encouraged *"Simple and practical changes can lead to improved energy, health and vitality".*

Feedback

"Really enjoyed the talk, everything was so clear and I don't have to try and do it all at once!"

"Talk was so informative and handouts will be really useful in helping keep me on track to make small and gradual changes in what I eat."

"Brilliant, thank you, I have been ill and I have learned so much that will help me get my strength and energy back"



Yoga - Shauna McMorrow
(Aurora Yoga Studio NI)



Yoga has many proven physical and mental health benefits. Practised regularly it can help improve Flexibility; Muscle Strength; Bone Health; Posture; Balance; Sleep and Relaxation; leading to feelings of Well-Being and Happiness.

"Who doesn't want to feel healthier and happier"? asks Shauna, who is passionate about the benefits of yoga.

Feedback

"Brilliant, first time in Aisling Centre and first time to try yoga, lovely to meet the other yogis"

"Amazing how relaxed I feel after each class, can feel myself getting stronger and sleeping better too"

"Great way to start the day, in a lovely peaceful atmosphere, thank you Shauna and thank you Aisling Centre"

Meditative Healing - Marie Evans
(The Medicine Bowl)

Marie's workshop initiated participants to 'Take a few hours to yourself, Learn how to be still, Quieten your busy mind and your anxious self, Relax and enjoy a workshop of Meditation, Movement and Healing'.

Feedback

"Wonderful experience, wasn't sure what to expect but I really enjoyed it"

"Thank you Marie, brilliant as always, everything perfect the venue, the music the smells. A wonderfully relaxing and healing day"

"Just what I needed some time out to relax and refresh"

HOPE HEALING, GROWTH

3rd Annual day of Inspiration and Healing

On Saturday 4th January 2020 a unique day of inspiration was held at SW College Skills Centre. As it has over the past three years, the event gave a positive start to the New Year to help ensure that every good intention made for the coming year could be closer to being realised.

The Hope, Healing and Growth event is aimed to help everyone explore self-care while raising funds to support the work of Aisling Centre. The event was particularly significant as it also marked the beginning of a milestone year for Aisling Centre, celebrating 30 years of tireless promotion of positive mental health and emotional wellbeing.

Attended by more than 450 participants the programme brought together national and local contributors all of whom gave of their time on a voluntary basis. The format included a mix of keynote speakers, life-stories and seminars alongside lifestyle and well-being workshops. All reflecting a common theme of self-compassion and hope.

Adrian Dunbar expressed his pride in being the Patron of Aisling Centre. In his address he recognised the tireless work of the Centre and its importance in the community it serves and supports, with dignity and respect. He highlighted the positivity of the HHG event and the vital role of Aisling Centre as a focal point for Hope in the community.

Aisling Centre founder member, Sr Edel gave a brief overview of the history of Aisling Centre and her joy when she reflects on the great work undertaken at the Centre over the past 30 years; all of which she said were beyond her wildest imaginings in 1990. She finished with a wry smile saying she could never have foreseen *"that 30 years later, I would be sharing a stage with a film star, the wonderful, Adrian Dunbar".*

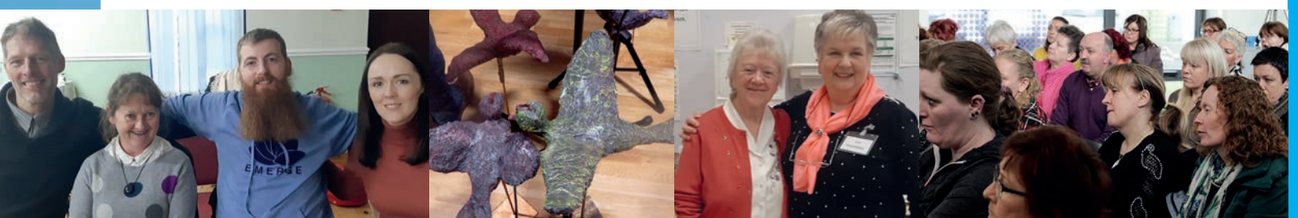
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As always Aisling Centre says a huge thank you to the organisers, the volunteers, SW College and the many contributors all of whom give their time free of charge. A fantastic donation of £6,051.63 was made to Aisling Centre following the event. These monies will be used to provide additional services at the Centre.

Coming Soon HOPE HEALING, GROWTH 9th January 2021

This day of positivity and well-being has become an established part of the local calendar because of the inspiration and creativity of Aideen McGinley and her friends Sheila Gilroy-Collins and Noelle McAlinden. And, as anyone who knows this trio will concur, it will take more than COVID-19 to stop these dynamic women! With the help of SW College and others, plans are afoot for a day with a difference which will undoubtedly have a virtual element.

So keep the date free – 9th January 2021 - and watch out for updates in the local press and on social media.



There is Always Help Available

Dr Agatha Stanek

Dr Stanek told her story of her battle with anxiety and depression at the 2020 HHG well-being day. She wanted to share her story to help others who may be struggling with mental health issues. She has very kindly agreed that we can share that story in our annual report. This is an abridged version of her presentation.



"We live in extremely fast paced times, times of social media, completely saturated with information and images. People display their perfect bodies, breakfasts, outfits and holidays, perfect relationships, engagements, weddings and children. If any of those pieces are missing or if you have trouble keeping up, it's easy to feel inadequate.

Battling anxiety and depression is not glamorous; it feels like something we should be ashamed of, something we should hide. It is still seen as somewhat taboo. Yet we are now very well aware that there are chemicals in our bodies responsible for developing mental illnesses, same as physical diseases such as diabetes or cancer.

My journey wasn't the straightforward. I'd say I was in my teens when I experienced depression for the first time, except I couldn't quite name it back then. Over the next number of years I suffered some very traumatic and difficult losses and with grief came depression. It came on quite insidiously, I felt anxious and tearful, my sleep pattern and appetite became disturbed and I noticed loss of enjoyment from activities that gave me pleasure before. Christmas was a crisis point for me, the future was bleak, it was simply unbearable.

I've looked up to my dad my whole life and there's never been a problem he couldn't resolve. However, I'm pretty sure, that Christmas, that there were moments when he felt a little hopeless not knowing how to help me. It was a wakeup call for me - I simply knew I had to do something.

I started by taking time off work. I saw my GP and restarted antidepressants. It was frustrating to be at that point again but there was no other choice. I started going to therapy, it was extremely helpful. The progress was slow, one small step at a time.

I remember a day in February when I went to IKEA to buy some plants for my apartment in Belfast. It was an unusually sunny day and on my way back home I remember thinking - "maybe it's all gonna be okay".

I started going to Zumba classes. It soon became my favourite part of the week - for the first time I was actually looking forward to doing exercise rather than dreading it.

Another thing that played a big part in my recovery was animal contact. Anyone who's ever spoken to my dad or me for longer than a minute knows that we have a beautiful Golden Retriever named Suzie that we simply adore. We even throw her birthday parties! I also volunteer in a dog shelter. I learned that physical work can relax your mind like nothing else.

Meditation was another important part of my recovery. My patients are probably sick of me talking about it but I do try to practise what I preach. I use an app called CALM and try to devote 10 minutes each day to meditate. Before I would spend my days ruminating about the past or worrying about the future; meditation taught me to live in the moment more because now is the only time to have. It also taught me to soften my emotions - both positive and negative, so they may no longer take me on a ride.

It only took me 30 years and a medical degree to realise that it actually does matter what we eat! I am ashamed to admit I've probably not had the best diet before, eating quite irregularly. I am now a fan of regular and a pretty bland but healthy diet.

There is nothing wrong with taking alcohol in moderation, but for me, taking even small amounts lowers my mood, so I try to stay away from it, apart from special occasions.

Today I feel happy, healthy, confident and loved. But I'm not taking any of it for granted - I know my depression can always come back. So I just wanted to share with you some lessons I've learned over the past 12 months and that I am very grateful for.

1. Be patient. The only thing that is certain in this life is change. A year from now, no matter what, you're not going to be in the same place.
2. Be kind to yourself. Learn to love yourself, all your little imperfections and speak to yourself the way you would to your best friend.
3. It's okay to be uncertain and to not always have a plan. It's okay to just let life unfold. In fact, that's what makes it more interesting.
4. It's perfectly fine to take time for yourself and to say "No" when you don't feel like doing something. It's okay to not reply to a text or a phone call immediately, to cancel a meeting, to take time out. Like they tell you on the plane – "Put your own mask on first before helping others".
5. Don't ever take your mental health for granted. You wouldn't expect your physical health to remain great if you never exercised and had junk food every day. Same goes for your mental health - it's a process that requires constant work. We all have different things that work for us - discovering what works for you and making it your daily routine is precious.
6. Never lose hope and don't be ashamed to ask for help. It's not a sign of being weak but of trying to be strong for too long.

There is always help available."

Agatha

Governance

Treasurer's Report

This is a special year for the Aisling Centre as we celebrate our 30th anniversary and our 30th Treasurer's Report. In those thirty years we have witnessed a world that has become more complicated and challenging. These challenges remain the same today – being financially sustainable and meeting the needs of our public. It is with pride that I can report another year of sound financial governance and good practice. We are fortunate to have staff who are dedicated and committed and coupled with an active and energetic Board of Management make for a winning team.

It is important to acknowledge the fantastic support we receive from our financial supporters at a local, regional and national level. Without this support the Centre could not operate so we thank the Western Health and Social Care Trust and the Victims and Survivors Service for their funding and investment. The Public Health Agency continues to support our work and we have been fortunate to receive continued funding from the BBC's Children in Need. Financial support has also been received from the Belfast Cathedral Annual Sit-Out as well as the Mercy Fund and support from the St John of God Foundation.

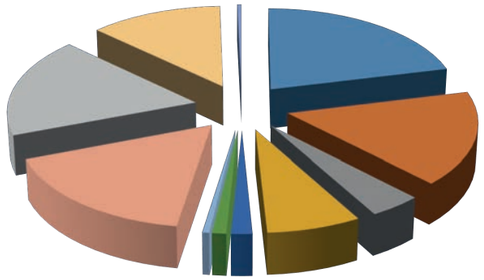
We continue to receive support through Neighbourhood Renewal and with support from different funds from Fermanagh and Omagh District Council. The Centre remained busy during the day and at night with groups using the facilities and the Westend Coffee Shop remains as popular as ever. We are genuinely grateful to all our funders and look forward to a continued partnership in the years ahead.

Aisling also enjoys the support of an imaginative and tireless Fundraising Committee. Their hard work and dedication have raised thousands of pounds and helped raise community awareness of the work of Aisling. Coffee mornings, sponsored runs and walks and the well-attended Hope, Healing and Growth events raised much needed funds and provided fun and learning for the wider community. This community awareness was further enhanced by generous financial support from Enniskillen Rotary and from Severfield. This support has been much appreciated; also the many in the community who have raised funds on our behalf. We take this opportunity to thank everyone who has given their valuable time to support our work.

Finally, we think of the challenges of the year ahead in uncertain circumstances. The role of Aisling as a place of healing and personal support remains stronger than ever, but with increased financial strain on public resources we must be pro-active in maintaining our sustainability. We are thankful for our relationship with the Sisters of Mercy for their wisdom and guidance and for the use of the building.

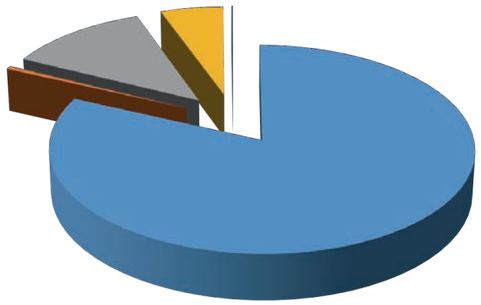
Neville

Income Breakdown



- VSS
- WHSCT
- PHA
- BBC Children in Need
- Mercy Fund
- NRA
- FODC
- Miscl Small grants/contracts
- Fundraising & Donations
- Room Donations
- Programmes / income generations

Expenditure Breakdown



- Counselling / Service Provision
- Fundraising & PR Exps
- Miscl Overheads
- Management & Admin
- Depreciation

Governance

Funder Acknowledgements

Western Health and Social Care Trust

VICTIMS & SURVIVORS SERVICE

BBC Children in Need

Public Health Agency

BELFAST CATHEDRAL

Fermanagh & Omagh District Council
Comhairle Ceantair Fhear Manach agus na hÓmaí

SAINT JOHN OF GOD FOUNDATION

NEIGHBOURHOOD RENEWAL

Strategic Plan

Vision / Dream
Positive Mental Health and Emotional Well-Being for All

Mission
To provide opportunities for hope, healing and growth in a welcoming and supportive environment

Commitment
- Striving to meet Professional and Ethical Service Standards
- Adopting an evidence-based approach within a robust outcome measurement framework

Principles / Values
- Confidential, Respectful, Empathic, Supportive, Non-judgemental and Inclusive of All
- Working collaboratively with others to achieve shared objectives
- Sensitivity to Current & Emerging Needs

Strategic Priorities
- To promote positive mental health and emotional well-being for adults, young people and children in Co Fermanagh and the surrounding area through the provision of an accessible and professional counselling, psychotherapy and play therapy service
- To provide a range of additional activities that will enhance and complement the counselling and psychotherapy work of the Centre and give additional value to clients
- To ensure that the Aisling Centre is an effective, accountable, transparent organisation that meets the requirements of all stakeholders













COVID-19

"Birds are singing louder"

"Birds are singing louder." A number of people have said this to me recently, in fact, I thought so myself. But birds have always sung; it is because of the *"lockdown"* that I am now hearing more clearly what has always been in the air, trees and bushes. *"Lockdown"* has brought an *"open up"* feel as I notice what has always been present though, I had not given it the attention it deserved. When I was a child in Monea I waited for the sound of the cuckoo. When did I lose that? In the pursuit of life, the world of nature and its sounds somehow slipped into the background. As reggae singer, Bob Marley once said, *"The day you stop racing is the day you win the race"*.

The earth finally gets time to breathe and I too get time; time to touch base with not only myself but, also with my surroundings. All of a sudden a bigger picture has appeared; that of survival. The Coronavirus has taken loved ones. It has no religion, race or colour. The knowledge it could be you or I makes us aware of mortality and the value of life. This awareness of mortality can perhaps make us kinder to others and less harsh to our sense of self in the now and future.

Keeping connections open and alive is important too. Aloneness can be a joy and so too can linking up with others. Technology has offered new ways of keeping these links and contact with others. Speaking on Skype becomes a new norm for technophobes like me. Contacts can be maintained no matter how tentatively.

I am impressed with how we are surviving and coping and how communities are coming together to ensure people are not isolated. There is a lot of advice out there on how to cope with the day-to-day living. From meditation, yoga, gardening, baking to anything else that might take you away from worrying about the moment. It is ok to cry too. Maybe it is time to take up a new hobby or do the jobs around the house I never got round to doing.

Life has slowed down for most of us and it may give us the opportunity to reflect on our lives and relationships with others, and, with the self. This pandemic brings a seismic change to the world as we know it. Change brings new challenges and with it the chance to embrace new experiences.

We are being resilient and this has to contribute to new ways of thinking. Coping strategies can be flexible to allow new ideas to grow and develop at this difficult time. We can still enjoy our pets, music, books, as well as each other, and, appreciate the nature and sounds that surround us. The importance of staying safe has to be thought of seriously and not only in relation to the Coronavirus. We have shown that we can adapt quickly to a new way of being and living and that anything is possible even in the most challenging circumstances.

Clare



Community Support

Sincere thanks to all the individuals, groups and the wider community who supported Aisling Centre during lockdown helping us to sustain our telephone/e-counselling service.

Virtual Counselling Client Feedback

"I started counselling in the Aisling Centre in February 2020. I wasn't necessarily in a really bad place at the time, but I had had a fairly traumatic work experience the summer before. I was working away from home and was burned out. I was working full-time in a stressful job, had an exceedingly busy social life and generally overfilled my diary. I had also been drinking too much alcohol - drinking easily ten or so drinks in one night. I moved home to Fermanagh.

I decided to go to counselling to get help with working on my mental health. My counsellor was excellent. Every session was so brilliant and cathartic, I always felt a bit lighter coming out of them. I suppose because I didn't go to counselling wanting to solve one big problem, so we discussed a lot of issues in my life.

In a lot of my sessions we discussed my parents' divorce and I was able to cry about a lot of things that I never had cried about. I found this really soothing as I had obviously just suppressed and compartmentalised the issue at the time and got on with things. Now I was able to release these emotions that had been repressed all those years ago.

My counsellor helped me express my problems and helped me reflect over negative things that had happened to me. I feel this was a constructive way to look at events and I could look back at something that I may have perceived as negative and look at it more holistically. This means I can look at events now and not see them as necessarily "bad" or "good" things. They are whole experiences that have good parts and bad parts. On one occasion we did a body scan and meditation, which was really grounding and calming.

The COVID-19 pandemic broke out during our sessions and we transitioned seamlessly to virtual counselling. I barely noticed the difference and don't think it made any discernible difference to the counselling experience.

Upon completion of my twelve sessions I can confidently say I feel generally much better. My mental health is in a much better place right now. I feel I can tackle life's problems now with more tools and resilience, and because I had such a positive experience with counselling I know I will definitely get counselling in the future. I am extremely grateful for the Aisling Centre".











COVID-19

Down Memory Lane

Aisling Centre - A Haven of Tranquillity

The Aisling Centre, a haven of tranquillity and hospitality in Darling Street, Enniskillen houses a coffee shop which is quickly becoming a successful community business under the Community Business Programme established in 1989 by the International Fund for Ireland and LEDU.
In September 1990, the Aisling Centre opened as a counselling, educational/training centre with an adjacent coffee shop. The centre aims to respond to the needs of the local community by providing opportunities for growth, healing and community development.
Visitors to the Centre can avail of a wide range of services including: counselling, training, advice and support and at the same time relax and enjoy the coffee shop which offers welcome refreshments at affordable prices.
The Centre's counselling facility is expanding due to the fact that people find the Centre a safe place to come for help. Fully qualified counsellors with specialist training in anxiety management, dealing with depression, family therapy, and alcohol/drug addiction are available Monday to Friday 10.00am - 5.00pm and evening appointments can be arranged where necessary.
At present most of the counselling sessions are available in the Centre but in exceptional circumstances counsellors are willing to travel to rural Centres.
One of the most comforting aspects of the Centre is that with all its activity and customers coming and going from the coffee shop, those people visiting the Centre for counselling sessions come and go almost unnoticed.
Additional external counselling agencies including CMAC, Relate, Fermanagh Community Addiction Team and NEXUS also use the Aisling Centre as their base.
A unique service is provided to the Community in the form of the Aisling Centre's extensive training courses. Day/evening courses/seminars at the Centre include:

- Confidence building, positive thinking, personal development, personal effectiveness and assertiveness for men and women and leadership skills.
- Communication skills
- Customer care
- Stress management and relaxation, e.g. yoga.
- Parenting classes for all ages
- Creative workshops, e.g. art, story telling
- Job Search and interview techniques

All courses are tailored to meet group needs and the Centre is anticipating accreditation for several of its courses. It is Centre policy to make personal development courses available to everyone. As a result, since September 1993, the Training Officer has been travelling out into the community to provide courses.
Liz McShane of Charities Evaluation Service believes; " The Aisling Centre provides a unique and quality service in an area of need. It has a strong sense of its vision and purpose and is succeeding in communicating its values of welcome and hospitality and fulfiling its objectives of meeting local needs."
The Centre also provides aromatherapy and ki-massage treatment sessions which have proved very useful not only in terms of stress management but as a service to compliment and support those attending counselling and personal development courses.
Senior citizens are also welcome at the Aisling Centre. Once a week, the Rainbow Club which consists of active senior citizens gather for various activities both recreational and educational.
Further extensions to the Aisling Centre are currently with the planning department for approval. Once approved, the new extension will include an additional conference room accommodating approximately 60 people, additional counselling rooms, a playroom with play area and a fully equipped kitchen.
The first issue of the "Aisling Centre Link" has been recently produced. This is a quarterly newsletter detailing various activities and developments in the Centre and offers its readers an opportunity to contribute their own ideas and comments.
For further information on courses available at the Centre contact:
The Secretary, Aisling Centre,
37 Darling Street, Enniskillen.
Tel: (0365) 325811.



Participants attending a Women's Personal Development class



COFFEE SHOP provides a warm welcoming atmosphere for all users. It ensures that clients using the counselling service are not labelled and are assured of anonymity.

Courtesy of ***Enterprise Today*** issue 22, Autumn 1994

Down Memory Lane

Reminiscences

My initial involvement with Aisling Centre came about in early 1996 when Sr Mary Conway, the then Centre Manager, approached me to undertake the design and project management of an extension to the Centre located in Darling Street.

Like many people at the time I was totally unaware of what Aisling Centre actually did and the extent of the valuable services it provided for the whole community. Although only in existence for a short number of years Aisling Centre had reached saturation point in terms of the space required to meet the ever growing demand for counselling.

The plans for the Centre included the provision of a significant extension project that would provide the additional space necessary, thus allowing the building to grow to a level that would enable it be in a position to meet the urgent demand; demand that quite obviously existed at that time but had not previously been acknowledged.

So with the support of The Lottery, The Sisters of Mercy and many others, including the local community; and, with a tight budget and a tighter timetable, we embarked on a project that would maximise the site and create the space that exists today - almost three times its original size. When we were nearing the completion of the project I was asked to consider becoming a member of the Board of Directors of Aisling Centre. At my first meeting I was persuaded to accept the position of Chairperson – for just a year, but by some strange twist the term stretched out until 2014. When I first started serving as a Director we had a team of six who met monthly.

For a number of years we experienced many highs and lows in our efforts to keep Aisling Centre open. Indeed for the two years prior to the appointment, in 2011, of the present manager, Bridie Sweeney, the Board actually presided over the day to day running of The Centre.

But despite the challenges Aisling Centre has continued to grow and to flourish. It presently has a committed Board of ten Directors and an ever growing and dedicated team of staff and volunteers all working together to meet the ever-increasing need within our local community.

Pat


Women's AID
FERMANAGH

Telephone: 028 6622 8809
Fax: 028 6632 8859

24 HOUR HELPLINE
028 9033 1818

4-10-2002

Dear Colin

Fermanagh Women's Aid Management Committee would like to thank you for your kindness in sharing your premises with us after event at 24 Church Street at the time of the fire.

We thank you for your understanding and we were heartened at the community spirit shown to us at this traumatic time from your organisation.

Our work with women and children suffering domestic violence has been severely curtailed but we are hopeful of resuming a full service soon.

Thanking you again Colin

Yours sincerely

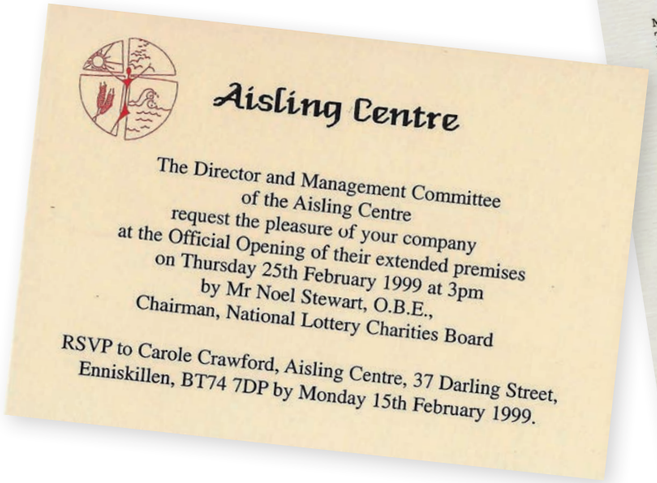
Brenda

Brenda Whitley
Chairperson

WHEN HOME IS WHERE THE HURT IS

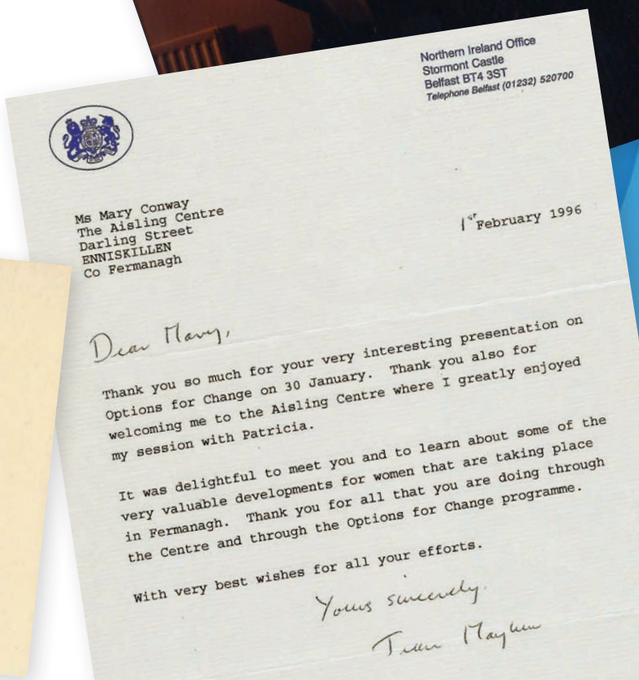
Charity No. XD1091/94




Aisling Centre

The Director and Management Committee
of the Aisling Centre
request the pleasure of your company
at the Official Opening of their extended premises
on Thursday 25th February 1999 at 3pm
by Mr Noel Stewart, O.B.E.,
Chairman, National Lottery Charities Board

RSVP to Carole Crawford, Aisling Centre, 37 Darling Street, Enniskillen, BT74 7DP by Monday 15th February 1999.


Northern Ireland Office
Stormont Castle
Belfast BT4 3ST
Telephone Belfast (01232) 520700

Ms Mary Conway
The Aisling Centre
Darling Street
ENNISKILLEN
Co Fermanagh

1st February 1996

Dear Mary,

Thank you so much for your very interesting presentation on Options for Change on 30 January. Thank you also for welcoming me to the Aisling Centre where I greatly enjoyed my session with Patricia.

It was delightful to meet you and to learn about some of the very valuable developments for women that are taking place in Fermanagh. Thank you for all that you are doing through the Centre and through the Options for Change programme.

With very best wishes for all your efforts.

Yours sincerely

Tom Mayhew

Community Hub

Counselling Services

ZEST

Healing the Hurt
SHIP – Counselling and support for people who self-harm
For information contact your GP or contact ZEST on

T: 028 71 266999
www.zestni.org

Support Groups and Networks

AA

3 meetings per week
For information contact the Aisling Centre

T: 028 6632 5811

ADHD

Adult support group
1st Thursday of the Month 7:00pm – 9:00pm
For information contact
Niall Greene or Emma Weaver

T: 07729618563
M: 07724916770
E: niaadhd@gmail.com

AWARE

A self-help support group for people who are affected by depression or bipolar disorder (manic depression)
Alternative Tuesdays 7:30pm – 9:00pm
For information contact

T: 0845 120 2961
E: help@aware-ni.org

ESCAPISTS

Support group for carers
Wednesday mornings 10:30am – 1:00pm
For information contact
Catriona Allan

M: 078 5134 1466

ETHNIC COMMUNITIES SUPPORT GROUP

Free advice & advocacy service
Available by appointment, every second Tuesday 10am – 4pm
For information contact
Nicholas Cassidy

T: 028 8224 9750
E: oecsg2@yahoo.co.uk

FORGET ME NOT

Support group for people bereaved by suicide
1st Monday of the Month 7:30pm – 9:00pm
For information contact
Fidelis Simpson

T: 078 4156 9000

SWEDES

(South West Enabling Deaf Encouraging Sign)
Deaf, hard of hearing, hearing and signing social network
2nd Tuesday of the month 7:30pm – 9:00pm
For information contact
Joan Thompson

T: 028 6632 5811

Workshops and Classes

ISLAND ARTISTS

Wednesday afternoons 2.00pm – 4.00pm
For information contact
Maura Newman

M: 079 6822 5704

YOGA

Alasdair McKay
Monday 6.30pm – 7.30pm
For information contact

M: 077 7629 0903

Jenni Brown
Thursdays 11.30am – 1pm
For information contact

T: 028 8954 1994

Christina Cornyn
Thursday 6:30pm – 7:30pm
For information contact

M: 077 2255 0040

Other Services

CHERISH SURE START - CRÈCHE

For information contact Maeve Linton

T: 028 6632 3153
T: 028 6862 1970

Westend Coffee Shop

Monday – Saturday 8:00am – 5:00pm

CAFÉ & OUTSIDE CATERING

For information contact Barry

T: 028 6634 0475
M: 0797997 5000

Every year 50+ organisations and Individuals use Aisling Centre as base from which to deliver programmes & services we thank them sincerely for their on-going support.



Candlelight, Christmas Carol Service

All Saints Mullaghfad Church, Fivemiletown, Candlelight, Christmas Carol Service, 17th of November. Organised by Wendy Crawford, with proceeds donated in memory of the late Ryan Breadon, the rural church was filled to capacity.

A cheque for £950.00 was presented to Stephanie Armstrong on behalf of the Forget Me Not, Bereaved by Suicide Support Group, Fermanagh,

The families involved would like to thank everyone who attended; the continued support is much valued.



AA Serenity Prayer

God, grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, the courage to change the things I can, and the wisdom to know the difference.

In AA, everyone is equal and it's anonymous, members are known by their first name only. *"Who you see here, what you hear here, let it stay here"*

AA meets in the Aisling Centre three evenings per week; Monday, Tuesday and Thursday. Meetings are open to anyone struggling with addiction.

For information contact the Centre on 028 66 325811.

Meet The Team

"I congratulate you and your team on the wonderful service you are providing for the people of Enniskillen and the surrounding areas. I am touched and inspired by your commitment and that of the team. Thank you for the inspiration and for the service you provide. I wish you and your team all the best as you continue this wonderful work."



Patron
Adrian Dunbar

Board of Directors
Ann McDermott
Chairperson

Alison Annan
Vice-Chairperson

Mary deLacy
Secretary

Neville Armstrong
Treasurer

Directors
Aideen McGinley

Edel Bannon

Iain Kennedy

Pat Cassidy

Marshall Coalter

Roberta Hamilton

Staff
Bridie Sweeney
Centre Co-ordinator

John Bennett
Clinical Co-ordinator

Patricia Kelly
Admin/Facilitates Manager

Clinical Team
Clare Love

Edel McGuiness

Mary Carroll

Sharon Fitzpatrick

Sessional Psychotherapists
Ann Farrell

Anna Frith

Brenda Wynne-McKervey

Fiona McCaughey

Helen Murphy

Holly Reid

Karen Whaley

Nicholas May

Nuala McGovern

Clinical Placements
Cahir Maguire

Denise Crudden
Rosa Furey

Rosemary Cupples

Administration Team
Fiona Beatty

Jimmy Britton

Joan Thompson

Marie Greene

Admin Volunteers
Bronagh Reilly

Margaret Corrigan

Rita Murphy

Sessional CT
Sheila Johnston

Sessional & Volunteer Mindfulness Facilitators
Aisling Sheridan

Mary Toland

Nuala McGovern

Siobhan Conlon

Susan McGandy

We would also like to acknowledge the role of our friends and volunteers, too many to mention individually, who play an invaluable role in supporting Aisling Centre through a range of activities including awareness raising and fund raising.

The Last Word

After many years of dedicated service three Directors of Aisling Centre step down from their roles on the Board. We thank them for their hard work and commitment to Aisling Centre, they will be greatly missed. And, in this our 30th anniversary annual report they truly deserve the last word.....

Reflections



"My association with the Aisling Centre began when it was a dream-seed in the hearts of three courageous women. Over the years I have observed that seed grow into a flourishing tree with branches extended to provide welcome and healing to all who need it. As I finish my term on the Board I am filled with wonder and gratitude for all who planted, watered, pruned and nurtured that tree over the years and grateful, too, for the opportunity to share the dream in some small way as a member of the Board. I am confident that with its committed Team of Directors, Manager and Staff this sheltering tree will continue to be a beacon of hope for generations to come".

Sr Mary



"Aisling Centre has brought light into the lives of many during the past thirty years and I know it will continue to shine brightly as a beacon of hope in the very uncertain times that lie ahead. It has been an honour and a privilege to serve on The Board of Directors and I extend every good wish to The Centre in its endeavour to ensure its spirit prevails, and in its efforts to continue providing a much needed service in our community."

Pat



"It has been a great privilege to serve with Board Colleagues of the greatest integrity and commitment to the Centre. The staff team continue to be an inspiration to us all with their faithfulness to the ethos and mission of the Centre. Not even COVID-19 could dampen their dedication and enthusiasm!

As Aisling celebrates its 30th anniversary, I am so proud of all its achievements and confident that it will continue to make its unique contribution for many years into the future. Wishing you every blessing."

Sr Edel

Aisling centre
Hope Healing Growth

When you need someone to talk to...
We are here to listen



Give Hope

Give 50p a Day

For 50p a day - less than the price of a pint of milk or a bar of chocolate - you can make a huge difference and help us to provide much needed services in a community where there is an ever growing need.

Your local Counselling, Psychotherapy and Well-Being Service

www.theaislingcentre.com

Help us to help others

Resources available do not meet demand for services.

In the last year Aisling Centre provided an average of 100 sessions of counselling per week.

We need your help to sustain this much needed service.

Give Hope

Give 50p a Day



In difficult times and faced with so many important causes, it can be hard to decide who to support. By choosing to give a regular donation to the Aisling Centre, you can make a huge difference in the life of a person in distress or despair.

Over the year, your 50p per day could provide counselling to help save a life.

How will we use your gift?

We will make your 50p count. Every penny you donate will be used to support service provision.

Can't make a regular gift?

Other ways to help us offer this much needed local service e.g.:-

- a one off donation
- donate in celebration e.g. in lieu of birthday gifts, wedding favours etc...
- a bequest in your will
- nominate us as your work place charity
- undertake a challenge eg sponsored walk

To give please contact

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Co Fermanagh, BT74 7DP

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Email: info@theaislingcentre.com

Aisling centre
Hope Healing Growth

www.theaislingcentre.com